

Italian, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/italian/lessons/

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Preface

This is the Italian volume of a wider project, and it is written for someone starting from zero, whose only shared language is English. Italian is taught one word at a time, and each word is taken apart — traced to its root (usually Latin), then forward to the English cousins you already own, so nothing is a fresh thing to memorise. *grazie* (“thanks”) turns out to be English *grace*; *giorno* (“day”) is the *journ-* of *journal* and *journey*; and *ciao*, the most famous “hello” in the world, once meant “I am your slave.”

Italian is the closest living child of Latin, so its words often wear their roots most plainly of the Romance languages. Where a sister language (Spanish or French, the other daughters of Latin) makes the contrast vivid, the book shows it — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of them is assumed; a reader who happens to know one simply nods along.

Three things shape every lesson: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of cousins; and the cultural or idiomatic reason a thing is said, not just the rule. Pronunciation is a short reference at the front, never a gate. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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Italian pronunciation — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — each lesson gives the sounds its word needs. This page just gathers them. Italian is gloriously **phonetic**: once you know these rules, you can read almost any word aloud correctly.

The traps for an English speaker

- **Every letter is sounded**, and vowels are pure: *a* (ah), *e* (eh), *i* (ee), *o* (oh), *u* (oo) — never the English glide.
- **c** and **g** are soft (*ch*, *j*) before *e/i* (*ciao*, *giorno*), hard (*k*, *g*) before *a/o/u* (*casa*, *gatto*). **ch/gh** force the hard sound (*chi* = “kee”).
- **gli** = the *lli* of *million*; **gn** = the *ny* of *canyon*; **sc** before *e/i* = *sh*.
- **z** = *ts* or *dz* (*grazie* = “GRAH-tsyeH”).
- **Double consonants are held longer** and change meaning: *notte* (night) vs. *note* (notes).
- **h** is always silent — it exists only to harden *c/g*.

Stress

Most words stress the *second-to-last* syllable (*giOR-no*). When the stress falls on the last syllable it is written with an accent (*città*, *così*, *caffè*).

Italian in the Romance family

Italian, Spanish, and French are all worn-down Latin. Italian stayed closest to the parent, so its *-ct-* became *-tt-* (*notte*) where Spanish went *-ch-* (*noche*).

and French *-it-* (*nuit*); and it kept final vowels (*giorno*, *notte*) that French dropped. The lessons draw these contrasts as they arise.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Italian greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” the day-parts, the article that carries gender, and the most famous “hello” in the world. Each word is taken apart to its root and its English cousins. *Practice lessons: lessons/IT-C01-*.md.*

1.1 *ciao* — “hi,” and the word that means “I am your slave”

Sounds you’ll need

CHOW — *ci* before a vowel is the *ch* of *church*, and *-ao* is one gliding syllable, like the English *ciao* you may already have heard.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ciao began as the Venetian greeting *s-ciào (vostro)* — “[I am your] slave / servant,” a humble “at your service.” That *s-ciào* is Venetian for *schiavo* (“slave”) ← Medieval Latin *sclavus*. The very same word is English **slave** — and, astonishingly, **Slav**: medieval slaves were so often Slavic captives that the ethnic name *became* the word for “slave” across Europe. So every casual *ciao* is a fossil of “I am your servant,” carrying the buried history of a whole people.

Why it’s said this way

ciao is **informal**, and works both coming and going (“hi” and “bye”) — for friends, family, peers. To someone you’d show respect, or on a first meeting, you reach instead for *buongiorno*, built over the next lessons.

(Doubled, *ciao ciao*, it's a breezy “bye-bye.”)

1.2 *buono* / *buon* — “good”

Sounds you'll need

buono = *BWOH-no*; the *uo* is a glide. Before a masculine noun it clips to **buon** (*bwon*) — *buon giorno*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buono (“good”) ← Latin *bonus* → English **bonus**, **bonanza**, **bonbon**, and (through French) **bounty**. Spanish, another daughter of Latin, made the same *bonus* into *bueno*; Italian kept it closer, *buono*.

Grammar Lens

buono **agrees** with its noun in gender and number — *buono* (m.), *buona* (f.), *buoni* / *buone* (pl.). This gender-agreement of adjectives is Latin's legacy across the Romance family. Before a masculine noun *buono* drops its *-o* to *buon*: you'll see it in *buon giorno*.

1.3 *il* / *la* / *lo* — “the,” and the gender it carries

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

il and **lo** (masculine “the”) and **la** (feminine) ← Latin *ille* / *illa* (“that one”), the pointing word worn down to “the.” The same *ille/illa* gave Spanish *el/la* and French *le/la* — and also Italian **lui/lei** (“he/she”). (English “the” is Germanic, unrelated.)

Grammar Lens

Every Italian noun is masculine or feminine — Latin's three genders (the neuter folded mostly into the masculine) collapsed to two. Learn each noun *with* its article. Italian has *two* masculine “the”s: **lo** before tricky clusters (*lo studente*, *lo zio*) and **il** everywhere else (*il giorno*); feminine is always *la*. Don't drill the rule — just meet *il* at the first noun, next.

1.4 *giorno* — “day,” and the road to English *journey*

Sounds you’ll need

gi = the *j* of *jam*; *gior-no* = *JOR-no*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

il giorno (masc.) ← Latin *diurnum* (“daytime”), from *dies* (“day”). That detour through *diurnum* is why *giorno* looks nothing like Latin *dies*: cousins are **j**ournal, **a**djourn, **s**ojourn, and **j**ourney (a *day’s* travel) — all from the same *diurnum* — plus **di**urnal and **di**ary straight from *dies*. Italian *giorno* and French *jour* are near-twins here; Spanish, taking *dies* directly, got the very different *día*.

Grammar Lens

giorno is **masculine** (*il giorno*). Plural *i giorni* — Italian marks the plural by changing the final vowel (*-o* → *-i*), not by adding *-s*.

1.5 *buongiorno* — “good day,” assembled

buon (“good”) + *giorno* (“day”) = **buongiorno**, “good day,” one word — the polite, all-purpose daytime hello.

Why it’s said this way

Where the casual *ciao* says “I’m your servant,” *buongiorno* simply wishes you a good day — and it is the **safe, respectful** choice with anyone: shopkeepers, strangers, elders. Used through the day until late afternoon, when it gives way to *buonasera*.

1.6 *sera* — “evening,” and *buonasera*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sera (fem.) ← Latin *sera* (“late [hour]”), from *serus*, “late.” English cousin: the rare *serotine* (a bat of the *late* evening). **buonasera** = *buona* + *sera*, “good evening” — *buona* in its feminine form, because *sera* is feminine.

1.7 *notte* — “night,” and the *-ct-* → *-tt-* rule

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la notte (fem.) ← Latin *noctem* (*noct-*) → **nocturnal**, **equinox**. The change is a *rule*: Latin *-ct-* became Italian **-tt-** (*notte*), where Spanish softened it to *-ch-* (*noche*) and French to *-it-* (*nuit*).

Latin	Italian	Spanish	French	English
<i>noctem</i>	<i>notte</i>	<i>noche</i>	<i>nuit</i>	night
<i>lactem</i>	<i>latte</i>	<i>leche</i>	<i>lait</i>	(lact-)
<i>factum</i>	<i>fatto</i>	<i>hecho</i>	<i>fait</i>	fact

buonanotte = *buona* + *notte*, “good night” — the farewell for bed (not an evening hello; that’s *buonasera*).

1.8 *grazie* — “thank you,” from *grace*

Sounds you’ll need

GRAH-tsyeH — **z** in Italian is *ts*; the final *-e* is sounded (two syllables in *-zie*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

grazie (“thanks”) ← Latin *gratiæ*, plural of *gratia* (“favour, thanks, grace”). It is the *same* *gratia* behind English **grace**, **gratitude**, **grateful**, **gratis** (“free”), **congratulate**, and **ingrati**ate. So *grazie* literally offers someone *grace*. (Reply: *prego*, “you’re welcome” — literally “I pray [it’s nothing].”)

1.9 The day of greetings

Italian	English
<i>ciao</i>	hi / bye (informal)
<i>buongiorno</i>	good day
<i>buonasera</i>	good evening
<i>buonanotte</i>	good night
<i>grazie</i>	thank you

Every piece from a Latin root: *ciao* (*sclavus*, “slave”), *buono* (*bonus*), *giorno* (*diurnum*), *notte* (*noctem*, via the *-ct-→-tt-* rule), *grazie* (*gratia*, “grace”). Next chapter: introducing yourself — *mi chiamo...* (“my name is...”) — and Italian’s *tu* vs. *Lei* (familiar / formal “you”).